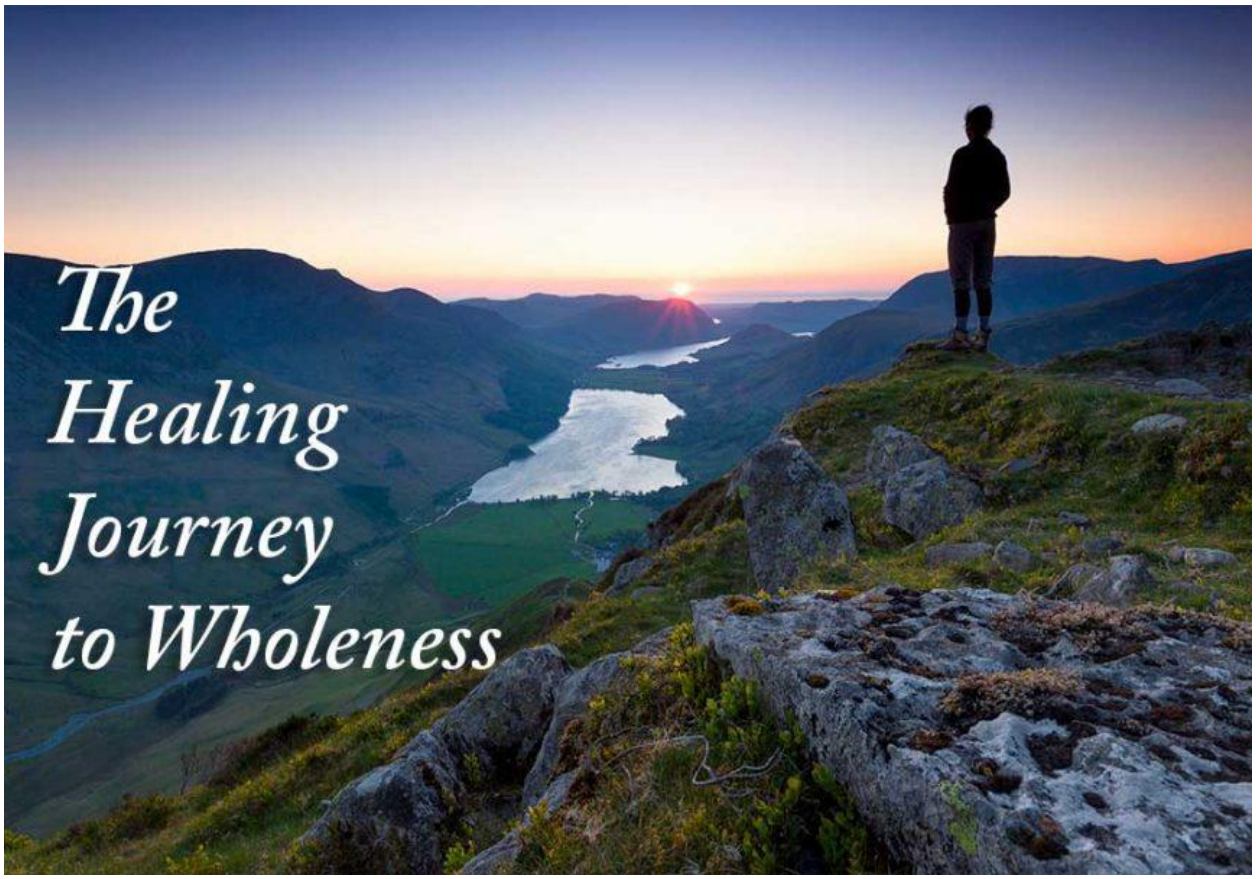
THE HEALING JOURNEY TO WHOLENESS



My healing journey is one of Self-acceptance, Self-compassion, Self-care, and Self-love. This journey has been so transformative that I have made it the cornerstone of my coaching practice.

Over the next few chapters, I will be sharing in detail each phase of this journey. Stay tuned and bring along your passport of possibilities!

SELF-ACCEPTANCE

“To be beautiful means to be yourself. You don’t need to be accepted by others. You need to accept yourself.” Thich Nhat Hahn

This is that powerful moment when I finally gave voice to feelings of disappointment, fear, anger, grief, blame, shame, rejection, and guilt.

I so often swallowed all of these feelings, cramming them down, walking them off, getting over it, and comparing myself to others that had it worse than me so that I might feel better about myself. Talk about denial! I did this for so long that my struggling became suffering.

In many shamanic societies, if you came to a Shaman aka medicine man or woman complaining of illness, they would ask 4 simple questions. The question was, “when is the last time you told your story”? They knew that holding it within would block the flow of energy and create dis-ease.

My next obstacle was the push back, that self-acceptance means I am accepting that this will always feel as it does. That is not the case. It means that this is how I feel, right here, right now, and I acknowledge and accept this to be the truth as it exists in the present moment. That does not mean it cannot or will not be changed. But without this step of self-acceptance, there is no moving forward without the weight and toll of dragging these feelings along with me.

“It is what it is, and I am ready to continue on my journey of healing open to all possibilities”. Thank you for joining me on this journey! To be continued…

SELF-COMPASSION, PART 1

“Unlike self-criticism which asks if you are good enough, self-compassion asks, what is good for you?” Kristen Neff

This quote captures my “before and after” transition through Self-compassion! I started this journey chock full of not enoughs. I did not know enough, I did not work hard enough, and I was not deserving enough. These limiting beliefs led to constant self-sabotage through inner critic questions such as, how can I accept what I do not feel I deserve? The darker it seemed to get, the louder and clearer the voice of my inner critic became, reaffirming and reinforcing beliefs that did not serve me.

I knew that I needed to embrace self-compassion because it would finally allow me to use a process of examination to decide what was good enough for me and if it served me enough. But this process was still being challenged and it would require me quieting the voice of my inner critic enough to allow me to even feel self-compassion. This took unpacking years of self-doubt and self-criticism as well as the willingness to bump up against the origin of these beliefs that no longer served me. These limiting beliefs had actually imprisoned me. There was finally a pathway in sight to help feel and remain free. I found EFT-Tapping to be exactly the self-empowering tool that I needed.

Stage One, Self-acceptance of my Healing Journey was finally giving voice to what I felt, be it disappointment, fear, anger, grief, blame, shame, rejection, or guilt. This step alone felt like a dramatic lightening of my load. When experiencing the power of what came next though self-compassion, my transformation took root. My capacity for consciousness, acceptance and self-compassion grew and soothed my inner-critic. Thank you for joining me on this journey and stay tuned because next, I will share what proved to be my greatest obstacle in incorporating self-compassion into my life’s journey.

SELF-COMPASSION, PART 2

“Having compassion starts and ends with having compassion for all those unwanted parts of ourselves.” Pema Chodron

Self-compassion is a practice that softens the heart and creates a ripple effect that is so powerful that it changes worlds. It changed my world that is for sure!

I was accustomed to having compassion for others. I was taught this at home, at school, in church, and in my community. I am all about being compassionate when I am able to heap it upon others. But I was so stingy when it came to pointing that compassion inward. I was a pro when it came to self-criticism, but I resisted self-compassion as if it were a sin!
Self-compassion was very difficult for me because I had confused it with self-pity. Self-pity heals nothing and I had seen it keep people I knew and loved frozen in a place of self-destruction.

Self-compassion by contrast, is healing and nourishing. And if I was healed and nourished, think about how rich my contributions to others would be. That felt right!

Through EFT I was easily able to blend self-acceptance and self-compassion. For example, here is a tapping script…

“Even though I feel this challenging emotion or physical pain, and I accept that it is what it is right now, and maybe it has been for a long time, I deeply and profoundly love and accept myself and am ready to continue on my journey of healing”.

Finding and using this tool was my first of many steps in what would be my next stage, Self-care! Thank you for joining me on this journey and I welcome the sharing of your thoughts and comments! To be continued…

SELF-CARE, PART 1

“Put your own oxygen mask on first.” Every flight attendant before every flight. (There must be something to it…)

The first obstacle I found while blazing my trail to self-care was the incredible guilt that came from the mere thought that I was acting so selfishly. How self-absorbed could I get? I was a father, husband, son, brother, uncle, friend, partner, employer, and I felt responsible for each and every person in my life. This was a responsibility that I took very seriously. It was one that I saw carried so lovingly, selflessly, and seemingly effortlessly by those in my life that had come before me.

IF and WHEN there was time to spare after taking care of everyone else or worrying about everyone else, THEN I could think about self-care…and not a moment sooner!

Looking back with today's clarity, this was a self-imposed prison. The reality was that I was blessed with the most understanding and supportive family and friends a man could ever ask for. At the time, that fact did not lighten my self-imposed load one ounce. I was far too busy "shoulding" all over myself!

Then I embraced the most incredible "cup and saucer" analogy. We all have a cup and saucer. I filled up my cup and then before I knew it, I was offering a sip to everyone in my life because I should. Over time, I could not keep up with the demand for the contents of my cup and it was drained!

No one was nourished by my empty cup. Neither the people I cared so much about nor I was served in this exhausting cycle! No one wins. That is where I was stuck, in a constant state of being drained and ultimately resentful.

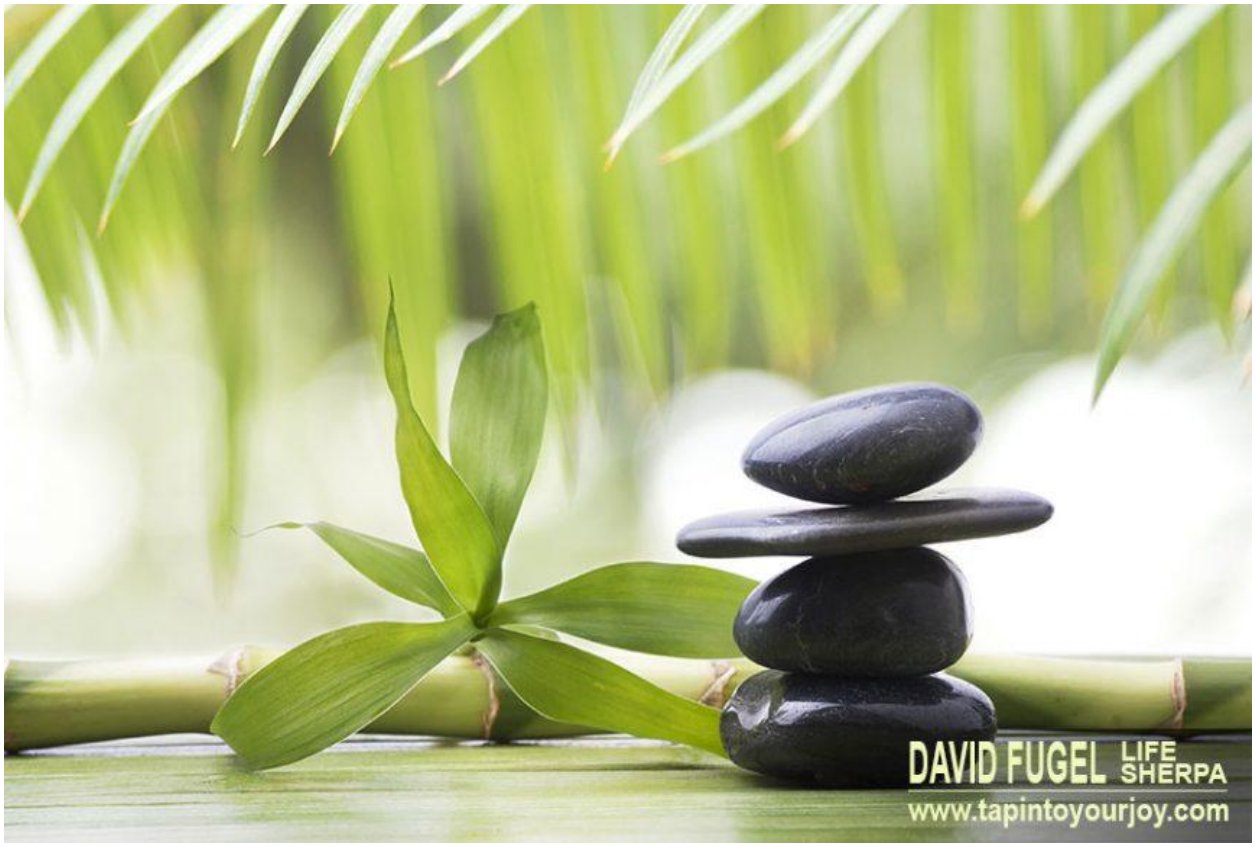
Then there was the turning point.

What if I only offered a sip from my saucer? I could constantly fill my cup with a magnificent, nourishing brew. That brew was a product of self-awareness, self-compassion and self-care. Eventually, the cup would be filled and spilling over into the saucer. I could offer everyone to partake from the saucer. There would be abundance for everyone else as long as I kept filling my cup and

sharing what was in my saucer. Suddenly, filling my cup did not feel selfish at all. It actually served everyone in my life, including me!

I could finally embrace self-care without feeling selfish and my journey and healing could continue. More about what that would look like to follow so please stay tuned…

SELF-CARE, PROLOGUE – THE SPARK



At times our own light goes out and is rekindled by a spark from another person. Each of us has cause to think with deep gratitude of those who have lighted the flame within us.

Albert Schweitzer

My entire healing journey has been a series of reading books and meeting people, each being a spark that would rekindle the flame within me. I had allowed my struggle to evolve into suffering. Perhaps, through my desperation for the suffering to end or at least ease, I found myself open and willing to find answers, a.k.a. the spark.

It started with a weight loss book, The Gabriel Method by Jon Gabriel, whose message seemed too good to be true. He opened my mind and heart to the fact that many of my physical issues—especially my weight—were emotional manifestations. So began my quest to identity the emotional issues that were affecting my life and robbing me of my joy.

Over the next few years, I discovered Esther Hicks' books Ask and it is Given and Money and the Law of Attraction, Louise Hay's You Can Heal Your Life, Wayne Dyer's The Power of Intention, Massaru Emoto's The Hidden Messages in Water, Thich Nhat Hahn's Peace is Every Step, Shawn Achor's The Happiness Advantage, and Martin Seligman's Flourish to highlight a few. One experience seemed to attract the next.

For example, I applied and was chosen to participate in a documentary with Jon Gabriel about EFT (a.k.a.Tapping) and Stress. It was such an amazing experience and introduced me to Emotional Freedom Techniques (EFT) and Carol Look, author of The Yes Code. In time, I was led to Dr. Dawson Church, author of The Genie in Your Genes. I had the privilege of being trained by both of these amazing EFT Masters.

Ultimately, what I learned is that EFT was the perfect tool for me to get to the big emotional "it/its" I had been searching for since reading Jon's book. It allowed me to compassionately dive into my beliefs and emotions that were controlling my life.

My curiosity about the concepts of Positive Psychology was piqued by Achor's and Seligman's books, which led me to The Flourishing Center and Emiliya

Zhivotovskaya. I was seeking to vet practices that had worked effectively for me—such as visualizations, affirmations, meditations, mindfulness and tapping—through the lens of science and scientific studies. Positive Psychology and The Flourishing Center gave me exactly what I needed with Positive Psychology becoming a cornerstone in my coaching practice.

I look forward to attracting and collecting new tools, ideas, relationships and opportunities that will serve me on this, my continued, joyful journey.

While I am not remembering everyone that has inspired and ignited my passion for the life that I feared would never be felt again, I look back with profound gratitude to you all, named and unnamed, hoping that I might provide a spark for those that struggle, feeling their flames have been extinguished.

Thank you for allowing me this opportunity. Much more about the vital stage of Self-care coming your way…

SELF-CARE, GRATITUDE

There are only two ways to live your life. One is as though nothing is a miracle. The other is as though everything is a miracle.

Albert Einstein

When it felt like my life was falling apart and the barbarians were at the gate, I would turn to gratitude. It interrupted patterns of panic and fear that did not serve me.

Gratitude transforms me into a conscious state of appreciation for everyone and everything around me. When I focus on objects of gratitude, I find more of which to be thankful.

I begin by asking myself, who or what am I most grateful for today? A tool that creates a powerful shift is called RAGED or Random Acts of Gratitude Every Day.

I would write a list of people or things that I am most grateful for. Then I send emails, text or notes of gratitude to those people on my list or those people that allow me to have the things that I am most grateful for in my present life. The rush is amazing, but the rush of getting responses from the recipients has become addictive. Hearing that I have made someone's day a little better or that my note was the best thing that happened that week fills my heart with joy. Suddenly, there is something that I know that I can control, and I want more of that feeling.

Everything is a miracle and for that I am so grateful. More of my self-care epiphanies to follow… Hugs and gratitude!

SELF-CARE, TRUST & ALLOWING

I may not have gone where I intended to go, but I think I have ended up where I needed to be.

Douglas Adams, The Long Dark Tea-Time of the Soul

The relief I experience every time I act from a place of trust and allowing is profound, but it is one of the most difficult self-care concepts to master. When things did not go as I had expected, I fought back, struggled, blamed and resented, which blinded me to possibility.

Shifting from why me to I am where I am for a reason that I do not know yet, but I trust and allow that there is something for me to learn from this experience, still does not always feel natural. Esther Hicks describes it as being on a rapidly moving river and we are in a raft with oars. Our inclination is to control our destiny, even if it is upstream. That fits in nicely to one of the limiting beliefs that I uncovered; “nothing good comes without struggle.” No pain, no gain. What Hicks says is that everything that we want, need, desire is downstream and all we need to do is take our oars out of the water and go with the flow. There is nothing for us upstream. WOW, what a concept! I will reach the place that I am intended to be when I trust, expect and allow this liberating concept of letting go. I have gotten off of the hedonic treadmill that I was on for my whole life where I chased success, only to find when I arrived there that the bar was inexplicably raised. Feelings of frustration and disappointment were the rewards for all of my efforts and sacrifices.

This letting go, trust and allowing has served me in so many ways. In fact, I have accepted that there is no destination other than having a joyful, loving, peaceful, and rewarding journey. I trust that this is where I am intended to flourish! Stay tuned for more of my self-care epiphanies to follow… Hugs, and gratitude!

SELF-CARE, GET CURIOUS

Millions saw the apple fall, but Newton asked why?

Bernard Baruch

I found myself mired in a struggle for self-care, but finally hungry for answers. I wanted to understand if there was something wrong with me. Was I different from everyone before me that had fallen and found their way to get back up? I just got curious. Why did I feel so negative? I stumbled on to the power of curiosity and the answers blew my mind. I WAS normal.

WHY SO NEGATIVE

According to the Cleveland Clinic:

- we have an average of 60,000 thoughts per day
- 95% of the same thoughts are repetitive, so we think them day after day after day…
- 80% of those repetitive thoughts are negative for the average person. This means that every day the average person has 45,000 negative thoughts.

Dr. Daniel Amen, Psychiatrist, calls these automatic negative thoughts (ANTs). It's in our genes! Optimistic cave men did not survive. The part of their brain that served them as pessimists is part of our brain and works the same way to "protect us".

It felt like it was still going to be an uphill battle but I felt lighter somehow. Just knowing that I was not causing it all myself was a relief and suddenly, self-compassion poured over me. Stay tuned for more of what I discovered about self-care in my healing journey.

SELF-CARE, MINDFULNESS

“Our life is shaped by our mind, for we become what we think.” Buddha

Before my healing journey began and as I think about the years I languished in the hopeless struggle to save our family business, I ate mindlessly, I drank mindlessly, I worked mindlessly, I loved mindlessly, and I lived mindlessly.

Looking back at that period, I realize that this was all an attempt to suffer under the rule of my toxic beliefs… mindlessly. The moment I became mindful of the pain, I knew that I had to do something differently in and with my life.

This is when I began attracting and accepting a stream of answers, concepts, and people that would ultimately pull me up and out of the deep hole I was in for much too long. They were everywhere it seemed. They were there the whole time, waiting for the spotlight of mindfulness to shine on them. In the coming months, we will explore mindfulness in practice. St

SELF-CARE, MOTION!

Emotion is energy in motion

Peter McWilliams

There is no way to shift your stagnant emotional or energetic state as simply or directly as MOTION.

Recently, I had a profound experience on a BLAH overcast, damp, cold winter day. I could not get myself out of the funk I was feeling. I was in a fog and completely stuck. While I was just sitting around waiting for something to shift, I did not like where my emotion or energy level was resting. Then it hit me! If “emotion is energy motion”, then I needed motion.

Taking action, I drove to a local trail and mentally committed to walk a mile loop all the while being present to all I could collect from each of my senses. The following is what I mentally collected and recorded during my mindful mile walk.

- The sound of sonic soaring airplane passing overhead.
- Swishing of the wind through the trees, swaying of these bare giants as if they were dancing in unison.
- The sight of the whitest of white surrounding me.
- The sight of charred looking leaves clinging from the branches of the fallen tree.
- The fallen snow, collected on branches like intricate lace.
- The cold odorless air, clean, and crisp, wafting through my nostrils.
- The moisture on my eyelashes freezing and fusing top and bottom with each blink.
- The slight burn in my lungs as I breathed in deeply the icy moist air.
- My dry tongue seemingly numb to any taste.
- Moisture running from my nose down the cleft of my upper lip and finally reaching the tip of my tongue, a burst of saltiness as it collects there.
- The ends of my hair over my eyes tickling my nose with each step.

- The sense of each muscle relaxing and all tightness that has existed disappearing.

This was my mindful mile. It transformed me and I felt my mood lifting. Possibilities were being created. The only question that came to mind was why I waited so long to take this walk! The bottom line is this: when stuck emotionally, creatively, or energetically, try motion and make it mindful!

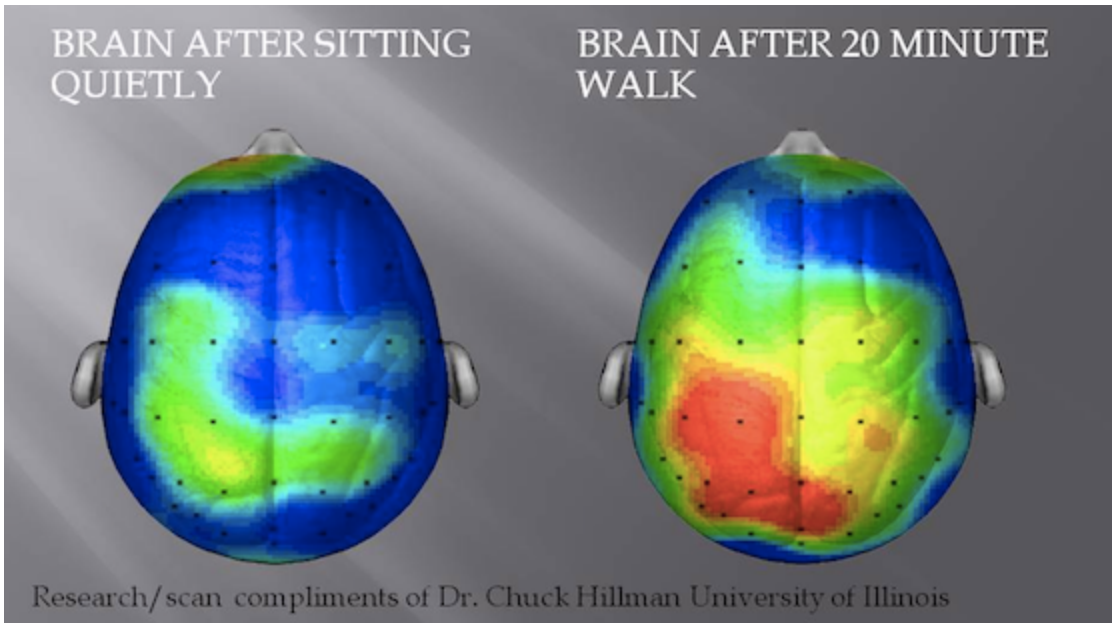


Photo Credit: Dr. Hillman, University of Illinois

SELF-CARE, LETTING GO

The root of suffering Is attachment.

Buddha

One of the most challenging transitions in my healing journey was letting go of HOW it was supposed to all happen. I would make calls, send letters, and picture in my mind how the dots were going to connect. Later on I would learn that the brain is a future dot-connect machine. It was not as if I was doing something I was not wired to do. But wired or not, it was not working!

The more I attached myself to a specific result and path, the worse I felt when the outcome did not happen exactly as I had pictured. Each time this would happen—and if felt as if it was happening constantly—it felt like failure. I felt like a failure and it knocked the wind out of my sails! I moved from struggling to suffering within this place of attachment.

Essentially, I could only see a VERY limited number of possibilities when in fact there were and are infinite possibilities in the universe unfolding and potentially at my disposal at all times. Attaching myself to the few that I could imagine is like taking DaVinci's paint pallet and leaving him with only black paint with which to create a magnificent work of art. That is not how masterpieces are created!

I came to recognize that my life and this journey is a work of art that is ever in process. There is so much for me to learn and so much growth for me to experience. Attaching myself to a specific pathway with my limited perspective is pure EGO driven. I attached to it because it is what I could relate to and within my comfort zone, knowledge, and experience. Accepting that I am an ever-expanding creator of my own masterpiece—ME—encourages patience, trust, allowing and curiosity. I don't know what I don't know but I am always ready to expand and trust the process of life. It keeps me humble, hungry, open and thankful that there is a world of possibilities ready to present themselves to my open and curious eyes.

SELF-CARE, SPEND TIME WITH THE WORTHY

Surround yourself with only the people who are going to lift you higher.

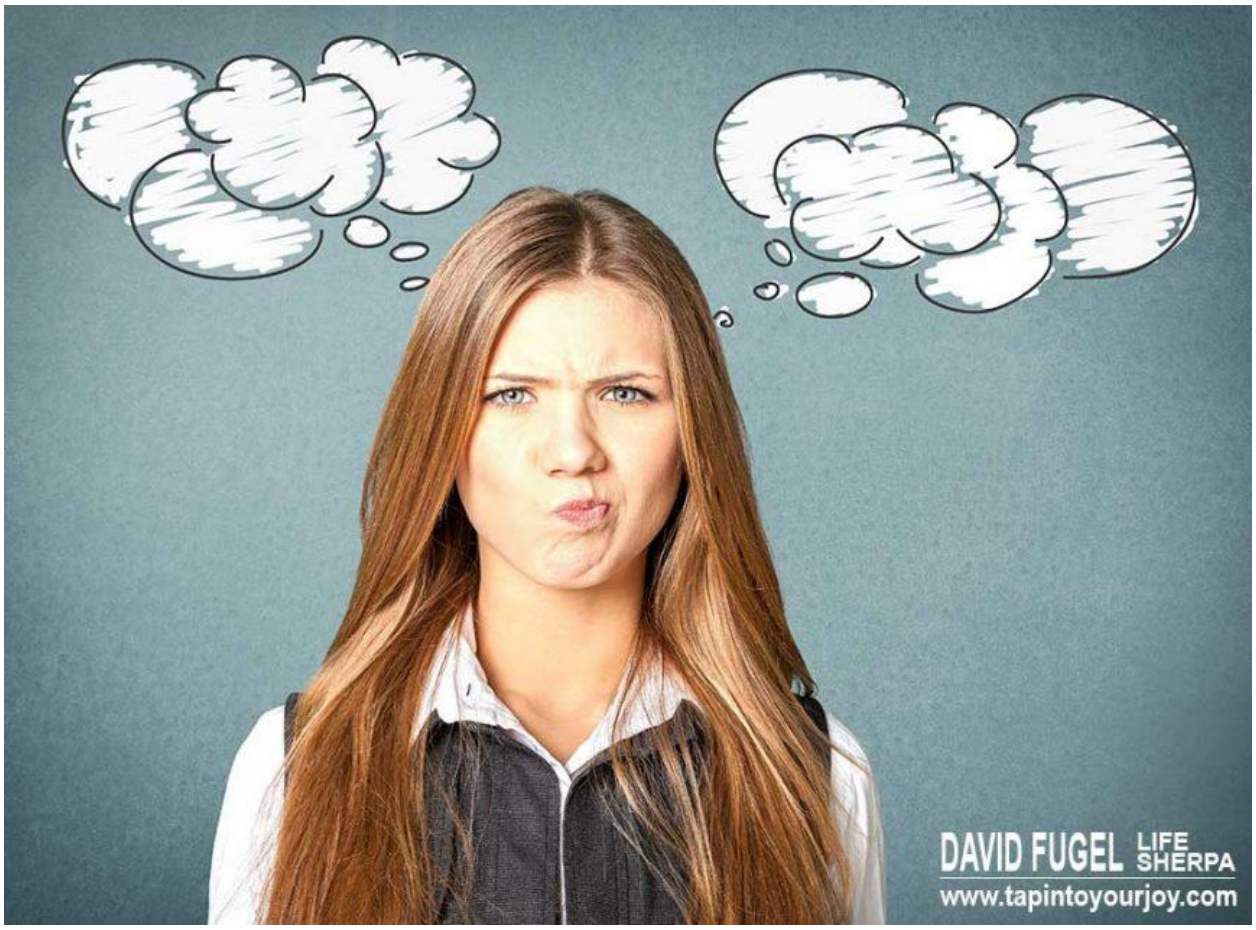
Oprah

When I arrived in a place of Self-compassion, I began to feel clear enough to take inventory of my “habits”. There were some that expanded me, and those that contracted me.

One of those “habits” was devoting time to friends and colleagues without discrimination. There clearly needed to be a distinction between those that helped me to feel supported vs. those that drained me. I read somewhere that we must “spend time with the worthy”. So, I visualized an amazing banquet table in a magnificent setting. I wanted every seat to be filled consciously by those people that filled me up! There is a song by Jackie Wilson, later covered by Rita Coolidge entitled “Your Love Keeps Lifting Me Higher (Than I’ve Ever Been Lifted Before)”. That is what I was looking for! They were people that I trusted and that I could be vulnerable and authentic around. When I imagined these people walking in a room, it made me feel light and happy. They might fill a specific purpose, such as financial or health advisor or they could simply bring a smile to my heart just because they listened and understood.

I realized that I had lots of “friends” out of habit, not of the heart. So many would “listen” without being present or really interested. It felt like they were listening out of obligation rather than interest. They were not there to honor me and most were there to tap into my capacity for compassion when it was I who needed it most in that moment. It was like playing a game of emotional musical chairs and only the worthy would have a reserved spot at my table. With the tool of Self-Compassion in my backpack, this was no longer a selfish notion. It was empowering and necessary. I wish everyone in my life peace, love and happiness… but I reserve seats for the worthy because they lift me higher and higher!

SELF-CARE, STOP COMPLAINING



Complaining is the act of relinquishing control to the very thing that is unworthy of it.

David Fugel

How often did I waste time complaining about stuff in my life, as if all of that “releasing” would make room for the good stuff? It never happened! Someone once said, “spending 5 minutes complaining is a waste of 5 minutes”.

So why is our focus and attention drawn to the unworthy and how do we get sucked in? My standard complaint was that the news was not news any longer. It was sensationalism intended to put us into fight or flight mode so that we could not take our eyes off of it. It was like passing an accident on the road, having all of those rubberneckers needing to see what they are missing as if it will make a difference in their lives or the lives of the accident victims.

Finally, one day, I had it with the news, my complaining about the news and everyone else’s complaining about the news. I did the only thing I could think of that felt like control. I tuned it out! I listened to books on tape, the comedy radio station, romantic comedic movies and music that lifted my spirit. Years of complaining got me nowhere. This simple shift in habit changed my world! No longer was I the guy to come to for a discussion of the latest shooting, protest, scandal, murder or pop scandal. The best thing is that I was not missing a thing! I learned bits and pieces about the “big stuff” because it is everywhere. But I was no longer feeling PTSD from stressing myself out with all of the fruitless complaining and bombardment of negativity. My body, mind and spirit LOVED me for it.

Now, when I find myself complaining, it is time to look closer. Is this something worthy of my angst, or is it something that can be eliminated? Either way, complaining is not an option because it comes at too high a cost!

SELF-CARE, PRESCRIPTION FOR “VITAMIN G”

Though the problems of the world are increasingly complex, the solutions remain embarrassingly simple.

Bill Millison

Our business was located across the street from Bryant Park in New York City. Upon reflection, as the business came closer and closer to its end, these times were when I felt my most anxious, frustrated, and hopeless moments.

I sat in the office immersed in relentless self-blame. Feeling the pressure of the world on my chest and in my heart, I felt as if I was suffocating under its weight.

I would desperately leave the office and walk to the park to soak in what felt like a healing energy and life saving oxygen. I really do believe that those moments saved me from an even deeper, darker place that I might easily have gone into without this refuge.

Expanding upon that lesson, I have begun a practice of grounding. It is my pursuit of getting a regular dose of “Vitamin G” which can only be acquired by finding ways to ground ourselves with the earth.

Whether it’s doing a “dew walk” in the early morning walking barefoot on the cool moist grass, kneeling in the soil digging through the earth to plant our herb garden and vegetables, walking barefoot in the sand, or even touching the strong trunk of the amazing trees that surround us, drawing from the energy of the earth is a vital part of my healing journey.

I cannot recommend grounding strongly enough.

Wherever you are, take advantage of this infinite FREE resource. This amazing gift is from something much bigger than us. Feel its healing power.

SELF-CARE, GETTING TO KNOW MY STRENGTHS

We have no weaknesses, we only have strengths ready to be developed.

David Fugel

I was introduced to the concept of character strengths through Dr. Martin Seligman and his VIA Strength Survey. Seligman has identified 24 character strengths. We all have them in varying degrees with the top-five really defining our character. Research shows that knowing, understanding and using our strengths increases our life satisfaction. This was something I was certainly up for. I did the VIA survey and learned a lot about my character strengths. I came up with a list of my strengths from 1 to 24. This list created the shift for me. What I always saw as my weaknesses were just lesser strengths. What a concept! And the great news was if I chose to develop the lower strengths on my list, there were strategies to do just that.

One item on the low end of my list of strengths was my curiosity. Curiosity is an amazing tool that can shift us from a fixed to a growth mindset. It enables us to go from the path of judgment to the path of learning. I connected to the reasons that I had been hesitant in the past to be curious as well as identifying the tools I would need to clear the limiting beliefs around it.

Now curiosity is one of my top strengths and I absolutely love it. It would not have been so obvious to me had I not seen my list and where my strengths fell.

Know your strengths and know yourself. Visit the VIA Institute on Character. Identify your top strengths and decide if there are any that would serve you to develop. Have fun!

SELF-CARE, BUY A BIGGER TRASH CAN

One of the secrets of productivity is to have a VERY BIG waste paper basket to take care of ALL invitations such as yours.

Peter Drucker

When Mihaly Csekszentmihalyi was researching his book Creativity, he requested an interview with the great management thinker Peter Drucker. Drucker politely declined the invitation, explaining that if he accepted every invitation, he would not have time to create. The quote above citing the iconic VERY BIG waste paper basket is from his letter declining the invitation.

I chose to expand the use of the big trash can for more than invitations. I use my huge trash can for anything that does not bring me joy. I enjoy living in an energetic state of constant “spring cleaning”. It feels like my creativity and productivity is squashed by the weight of energetic clutter. For me, the definition of energetic clutter is anything or anyone that I keep around or accommodate that does not feed my soul.

For so many years, I kept tons of clutter around out of obligation, nostalgia, denial, blame, guilt and confusion. It seemed to be what everyone else was doing or expected, so why not? Little did I know the toll that dragging this clutter collection of people, obligations, and responsibilities was taking on my life, my creativity, my productivity and my joy.

Years before I found clarity around this subject, I accepted an invitation to a milestone birthday party for a business acquaintance. It would require my wife and me leaving our 5-year-old daughter for the weekend to fly to this event. The plan was for my daughter to go to the beach with family members and we would meet up after our trip for a short vacation together. Everything went wrong including us showing up at the airport late for our flight and without our garment bag for the event. The blame game went into full effect! What bubbled up, after much shouting, was the fact that neither of us wanted to take this trip. As we calmed down, we realized that it was not important to either of us or to our business. I had chosen to accept the invitation at great personal sacrifice, simply to demonstrate how important my relationship was with this colleague. Talk about a decision that created energetic clutter! We decided to drive home and pack our bags for the beach. We explained that we had to miss the celebration and sent a lovely gift. I realize that I have spent

most of my career doing what I thought others would like me to do, or keeping and collecting things that I thought I needed to keep.

My trash can is now HUGE and at the ready. As soon as something feels obligatory rather than exciting, curious or joyful, it gets gleefully pitched! No regrets.

SELF-CARE, COMMUNICATION

The biggest problem with communication is we do not listen to understand. We listen to reply.

Steven Covey

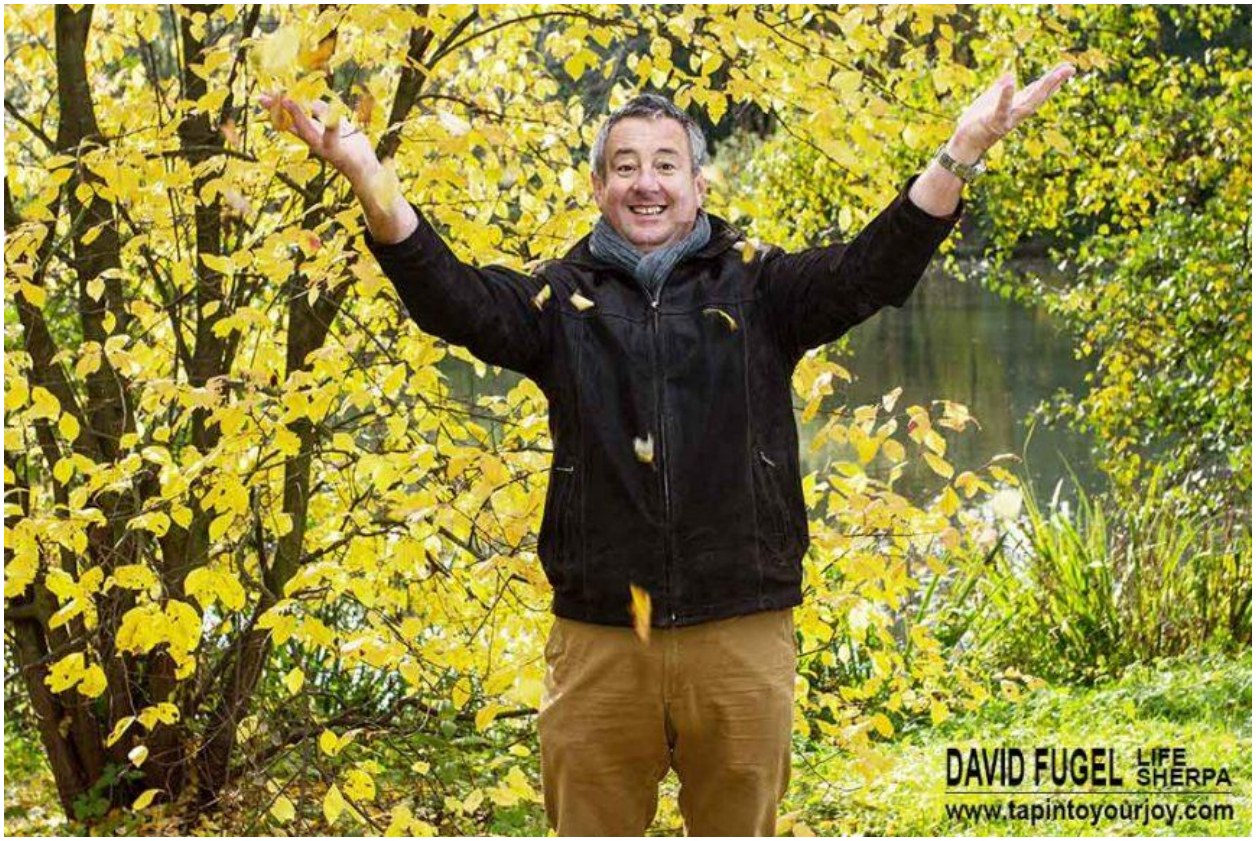
After I read this quote, its truth shot right through me. I vividly remember “acting as if I was listening”, while in fact I was consumed by the process and pressure of coming up with something “profound” to say! I did this in class, with friends, and in business. It was second nature. My ego had run amuck. Learning was not a priority and understanding was irrelevant. It was all about my ability to spout some seemingly appropriate or even inspiring words of wisdom. It was an endless cycle of lose lose!

A friend recently sent me a haunting version of Simon and Garfunkel’s “Sound of Silence”. The words, “People talking without speaking, people hearing without listening…” struck a chord. Although it was difficult for me to believe, I was part of creating that cycle of not speaking and not listening. One of the fringe benefits of hitting bottom emotionally was the humility that came with that process. I truly felt like I had nothing to say that would change or contribute to the world so I began listening. Listening to understand, listening to grow, listening to change.

While in that darkness, I came to realize that I didn’t need any sage advice and I didn’t need any special instructions. Those inspired words were not going to take me where I needed to be. I needed to speak from my heart, and from within my truth, so that I could just put “it” out there amidst my shame and guilt. It was not about anyone hearing it and saying something to make me feel better. It was about letting those words and feelings rush from deep within me to finally see the light of day. That was where the relief began.

Today, as I guide clients through their troubled waters, (sorry…had to), what is important to their healing, is connecting with them through listening to understand, NOT to make a reply. This is my calling. I am here to break the sound of silence.

SELF-CARE, EMBRACE THE SEASON



Savor the pace, nature, harvest and rhythm each season creates.

David Fugel

During the dog days of summer this year, the customary joy of writing my blog felt more like a struggle and a chore.

As I dug into these feelings, it hit me… “It’s SUMMER!“ The weather was beautiful and outside is where I wanted to be. Sitting at a computer felt suffocating and I chose to honor what was coming up. I decided to take a summer vacation from my blog and it felt liberating!

I chose to relax and fully embrace the season. I would slow down and replace the pressure of writing the blog with long walks, trips to the ocean, and time in nature. Even my meal choices were local veggies and salads that I knew would soon be a distant memory. PESTO is like pure sunshine and of course, lots of fish.

I felt like I was in the flow of summer, as I was intended to be. And everyone survived without having my weekly blogs. LOL.

But, I am back… replenished, inspired and looking forward to embracing autumn.

THE OFF SWITCH?

“Make a wish, take a chance, make a change, and breakaway.

Kelly Clarkson

What do donuts, pornography, and social media have in common?

Let’s start with donuts. Sugar, flour, deep fried and you guessed it, rolled in sugar. When it comes to feeling nutritionally satiated, donuts do not trigger the “off switch”. We can eat a dozen donuts and the switch does not get triggered. Most foods void of nutrition have this in common and plays a big part in our country’s sugar addiction and skyrocketing diabetes statistics.

But what does this have to do with pornography and social media?

All of these things: donuts, pornography and social media are consumed to fill a void. Porn scratches the itch (no pun intended) for intimacy without vulnerability. There is an epidemic among American males between the ages

of 15-25 who are addicted to watching porn. Porn is as accessible as checking the weather! The outcome has been a generation of young males who have dysfunctional sexual relations with their significant other. The addiction is the result of what is missing from this habit. In fact, what brought them there in the first place—as hunger brought them to the donuts—does nothing to fill that void because it is lacking nutrition or feeding of what is desired which is intimacy.

Porn is devoid of the very features sought after by its audience. There is no tactile or sensory satisfaction, no warmth or intimacy, so the viewer keeps coming back to fill this desire but to no avail.

This brings us to the fallacy of Facebook. Some are addicted to the attention that “likes” and “shares” bring in that moment. The fact is that all social media lacks the deep social connection, the warm touch that comes from someone else that completely loves us just as we are in that instant. Yet, we are drawn to social media to fill that void, the very thing our souls crave! Again, it is flawed.

We are hooked in trying to squeeze something out of this experience that will never be. There is no “off switch”, thus we are never satiated. In fact, we are starved nutritionally or emotionally. It is like pumping gas into our tanks. At the point that our tank is full, it automatically clicks off. If that gas pump was pumping only air, we could be there until the cows come home and it would not shut down or click off.

Then there is the guilt and shame of our obsession from these fruitless addictions. So how do we break these cycles? Ask yourself the question, “How can I change these behaviors in a way that my needs and desires are being satisfied?” With awareness and clarity, we can find pathways to upgrade our habits and tap into your joy!

FOMO FEVER

“For everything you have missed you have gained something else.”
Ralph Waldo Emerson

FoMO… FEAR of MISSING OUT…

“the uneasy and sometimes all-consuming feeling that you’re missing out – that your peers are doing, in the know about, or in possession of more or something better than you”.

Under this framing of FoMO, nearly three quarters of young adults reported they experienced the phenomenon.

My first run in with FoMO was with a colleague. There was an upcoming seminar which she admittedly had no time, money or interest in attending. When she took the pulse of a group of friends and a few indicated that they would be attending, she became anxious and consumed with attending. It was as if a switch had been turned on. She had FoMO FEVER.

Findings show those with low levels of satisfaction of their fundamental needs for competence, autonomy, and relatedness tend towards higher levels of fear of missing out as do those with lower levels of general mood and overall life satisfaction.

While happiness and life satisfaction are the antibodies for FoMO, emails and social media are the perfect carriers for this fever.

Our phones are always at our side and the overriding fear that someone might post something that we will miss is a sad statement of what gives life meaning. There must be emptiness, even a sadness that needs to be filled to resort to such desperate measures. And the comparison we find ourselves doing with the Facebook Fallacy of a happy, well-balanced and fulfilled lives does nothing be rob us of any joy and meaning or our experiences.

What is the FEVER treatment to combat FoMO? We need to fight the sadness and fill the void with rich, deep social connections. Put down the

damn phone and be present. Joy and happiness are about attention. If we give attention to them, they will be felt.

Finally, there are blessings and miracles all around us. Turn to gratitude on a regular basis. With these interventions, FoMO will be a thing of the past!

FEAR BEHIND OUR JOY

Most of us experience a life full of wonderful moments and difficult moments. But for many of us, even when we are most joyful, there is fear behind our joy.

Thich Nhat Hanh

When I read this simple statement, it's powerful truth stirred deep emotions within which I knew had to be explored. As I peeled away the layers, the first emotion that revealed itself was "shame".

SHAME

I remember an exact point in my life that everything I had ever dreamed was right there before me. More than I had ever dreamed in fact. I have a talented, beautiful and patient (very necessary if you know me) wife, a young daughter who was a brilliant, beautiful, joy-filled child, a family that loved and supported me completely, celebrations full of love and laughter with my family, and a business that was at its peak while providing the "financial security" that I had always longed for. I was on a mission to drink in every moment. In those moments I knew what joy was and it was magnificent.

What I did not disclose in the statement "I was on a mission to drink in every moment" was the chronic tailender…"WHILE IT LASTED".

The fact was that even in those magnificent moments, there was an undercurrent of fear that was extremely uncomfortable and most unsettling. It was leeching my joy! And adding insult to injury, I was so ashamed of feeling this fear.

What was wrong with me? Who feels this way when they sit on top of the world?

There was a sense of dread that it would all come tumbling down. I know a huge part of this was feelings of undeserving or unworthiness. It was mine only to borrow. I was deserving of a taste, but not the whole enchilada. I know, even while writing this, my inner critic is screaming "How warped was this thinking!"

It was just like Grandma's Italian saying, which translates to, "don't laugh too hard today because if you do, tomorrow you will be crying!" I hated hearing that as a kid, but there I was living that fear.

VINDICATION

The next feeling that I uncovered when I was looking into what was stirring within was that of vindication. "So I was not the only one that has experienced this!" Even after all of the introspective work and clearing I have done, it still feels good to read those words. It defines the struggle I was too ashamed to give a voice to.

The bittersweet part of all of this is that it did not last. We lost our business, most of our life's saving, and my identity.

Did my fear manifest the failure of our business and our loss of financial security? I am sure it played a part. As the fear replaced the joy, I lost my intuition. My clarity of intention was mired in the fog of fear. I would try anything and everything to save the business, like flinging mud against the wall and seeing if it would stick. Definitely NOT a recipe for success.

I firmly believe that clarity of intention leads to inspired actions. In this grip of fear, there were desperate actions that felt necessary, not inspired actions.

As it became inevitable that the business would fail, I desperately searched for ways to save myself from the weight of this failure for fear it would drag me down for good.

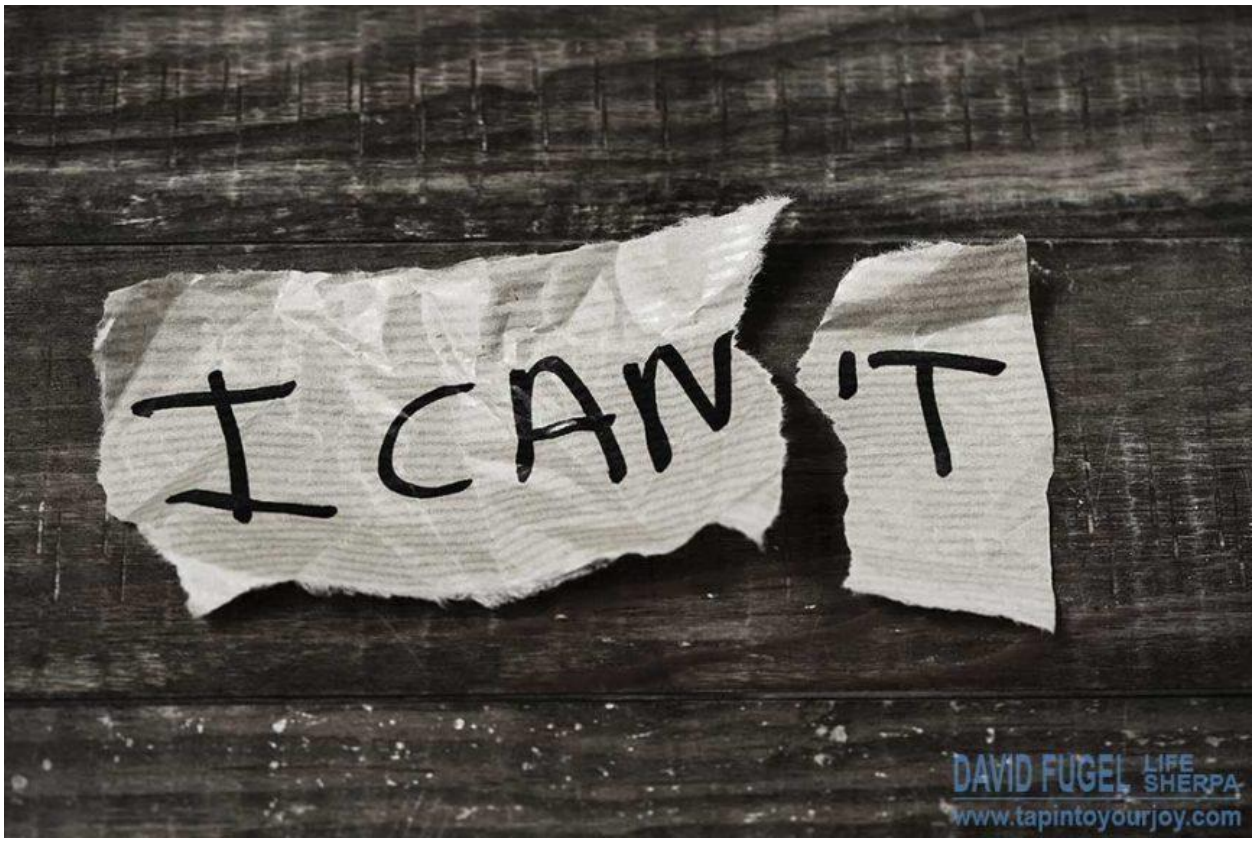
I wanted to end this chapter and begin the next with grace. I wanted to keep my family close and not lose them in the fog of the "war" that had been my life for 5 years.

I am thankful and joyful to say that our family has flourished. And the next generation that has witnessed our shared grace in failure have learned an invaluable lesson.

So, what is my antidote to the reality that even when we are most joyful, there is fear behind our joy? It is now and always will be gratitude. I will stay present, and turn from fear of what might be, toward deep and unabiding gratitude for what is.

I hope that we have the opportunity to change grandma's Italian saying to share with our grandchildren a wish to "ridere e amare oggi e domani sarà grato" which translated means, "laugh and love today and be grateful tomorrow!"

SELF-CARE, TAP INTO THE POWER OF SELF-EFFICACY



They are able who think they are able.

Virgil

I fell in love with the concept of self-efficacy aka self-belief, because it plays such a strong part in the trajectory of our lives. How?

- It influences the choices we make.
- It impacts the effort we put forth.
- It influences how long we persist when we confront obstacles and find ourselves in the face of failure.
- It impacts how we feel.

According to Albert Bandura, "*People's beliefs about their abilities have a profound effect on those abilities. Ability is not a fixed property; there is a huge variability in how you perform. People who have a sense of self-efficacy bounce back from failures; they approach things in terms of how to handle them rather than worrying about what can go wrong.*"

Because students with high levels of self-efficacy have confidence in their abilities to meet their goals, they tend to set higher expectations and demonstrate greater effort.

So how do I tap into the mojo of self-efficacy? I start the day with something that is infinitely doable. Rather than setting the goal of 30 minutes of meditation, I choose to open my eyes every day and recite my favorite affirmation. It is something to build on. I feel positive and good about that accomplishment before I even get out of bed. Of course, that leads to carving out time to meditate and journal, but it is a building process.

I do the same thing with exercise. Rather than committing to walking for 1 hour every day, my goal is to get up, get my running shoes on and check out the weather with a 5-minute walk. While I am out there, I decide if I have time

to walk another 15, 30, 60 minutes, but the process begins with succeeding at a very doable task for me, and I build from there.

If you are starting from zero, even a very small, very doable goal is an accomplishment. We build on our accomplishments and realize that we are able because we see evidence, which allows us to think we are able!

SELF-CARE, RECONNECTING WITH IMAGINATION

Imagination is the creative ability to form images, ideas, and sensations in the mind without direct input from the senses, such as seeing or hearing.

Merriam-Webster Dictionary

Recently, I was walking outside and listening to my favorite “happy music” playlist. I came upon a row of maple trees dropping their helicopter-like seed pods in piles all over the ground. I was suddenly catapulted back to my childhood. Where I grew up in New Jersey, there were not many trees but I remember there was this one huge maple. I loved when the sky was full of helicopters falling earthbound. As you can imagine, I collected as many as I could to bring home to play with.

There were many uses for them. I used them as helicopter support for my toy soldiers, or I would slit them and split the pod and stick it to my nose, or I used them as machetes for my GI Joe, and I am sure there were many other uses I am not recalling. How do I know this? Because these helicopters entertained me for hours and hours.

I was immediately struck by how imaginative I had been, how fun it was, and how little I exercised my imagination muscle.

I decided there and then to spend the next month finding opportunities to open myself up and plug into my imagination.

SELF-CARE, SHARE THE POWER OF GRATITUDE

Gratitude unlocks the fullness of life. It turns what we have into enough, and more. It turns denial into acceptance, chaos into order, and confusion into clarity. It can turn a meal into a feast, a house into a home, and a stranger into a friend. Gratitude makes sense of our past, brings peace for today, and creates a vision for tomorrow.

Melanie Beattie

It’s a beautiful autumn day in New England. It is the last day of parents weekend 2016 at my daughter’s college and we are about to leave to take the 3-hour drive home to our empty house. My father-in-law once said that a house has no heart unless it has a grandparent or child in it. He was SO right!

Even though my heart was full of the wonderful memories of this beautiful weekend, I felt myself getting a little quiet. A bit of sadness made its way into my thoughts. I was thinking, “This would be the last time we would be together until Thanksgiving weekend. There would only be one more of these weekends in our future.” One unpleasant thought after another crept into my consciousness.

At her college, there is this beautiful forest alongside a river. I suggested we get on the trail and take a walk. Motion creates emotion and I did not want this day to be hurried away, and I needed to snap out of it!

As we walked and talked, I was trying to be present and not let my thoughts drift to what I could not control. My intention was to enjoy every step as I savored our late afternoon walk.

Suddenly, we came upon an opening in the trees, and here we saw in the clearing what appeared to be hundreds of autumn-colored fabric rags attached to lines of rope. Even before I could see that there was writing on the fabric, I knew that we had stumbled onto something special… something intended for us in this moment.

As we got closer, thankful was written on top of one of the fabric pieces. We had discovered what looked like a “gratitude garden”.

The quote above was displayed on a sign with an explanation. In 2011, a week before Thanksgiving, this place was created. The intention of the

“gratitude line” was to be by the river to create a reflective place for people in the community to share their gratitude publicly, yet anonymously. It could be a wish, poem, prayer for something or someone. What a powerful gift for the giver and the receiver!

I think this is a beautiful idea and I intend to encourage my town, school, corporate clients and family to start their own “gratitude line” or “gratitude gardens”. Enjoy yours!!!

SELF-CARE, POST TRAUMATIC RESILIENCE

"Blessed are the hearts that can bend, for they never can be broken."

Albert Camus

According to Dr. Robert Scaer, when faced with a perceived threat, we can react with fight, flight or freeze. We are now learning that in freeze reaction, trauma can be trapped in our bodies and psyche.

The components of trauma are **UDIN**:

- **U**nexpected
- **D**ramatic
- **I**solating
- **N**o Strategy aka Helpless

Resilience begins with an awareness of the negative learning of a traumatic event. This is where you can tap into your Post Traumatic Resilience with self-awareness and curiosity.

“What did you make that event mean about your power and about the world?” Then follow up with, “and what did that mean?”

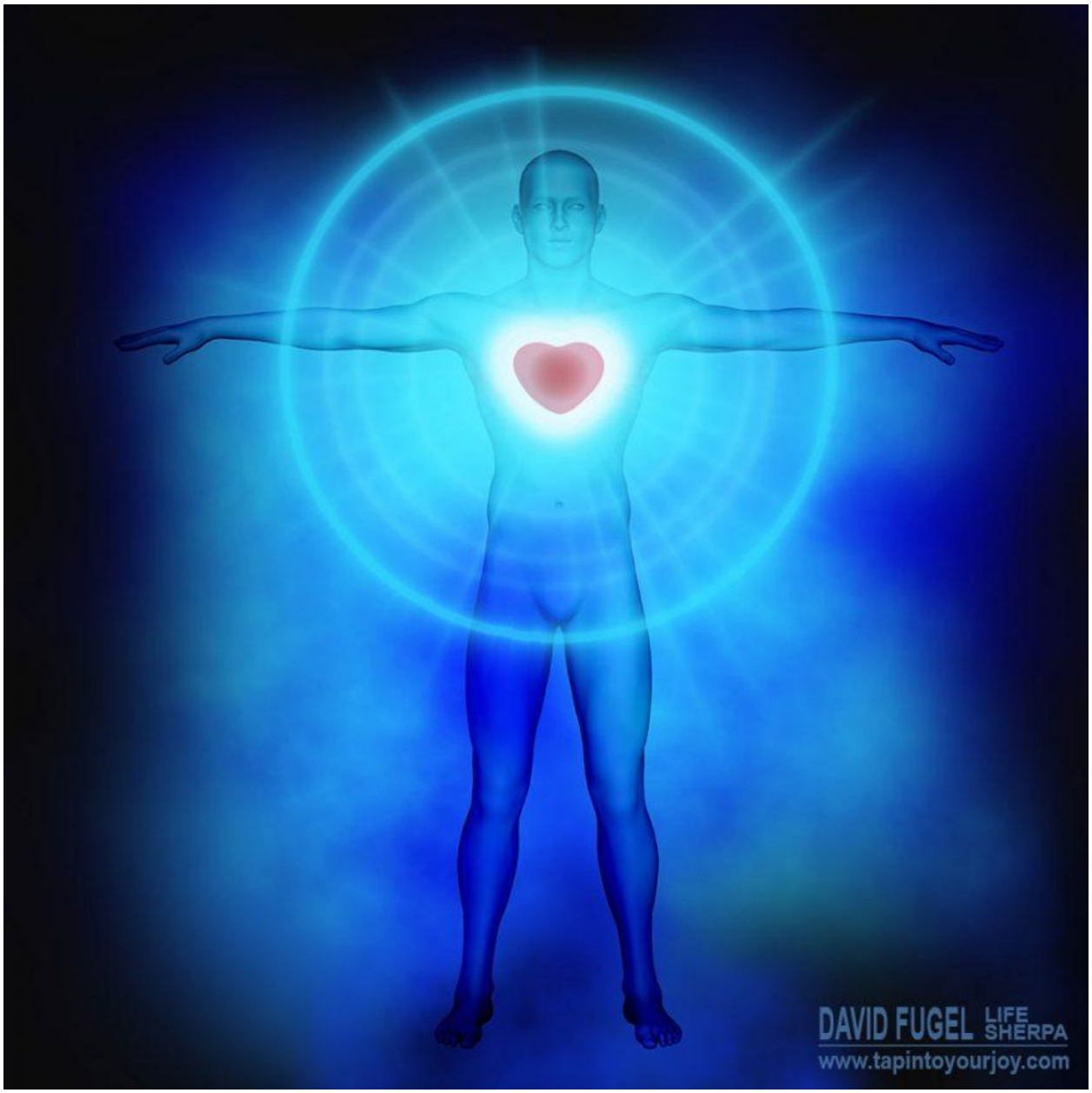
For example, if you were assaulted and no one came to your rescue, your negative learning about the meaning about your power and your world might be, “I am not safe or I am never safe.” And that could mean, “the world is not safe.” These beliefs are trapped in your body and psyche.

It is important to note that every event can be interpreted uniquely depending upon our individual interpretation of that event. It is very personal and completely individual, and there is no such thing as a universal response. Therefore, there is no universal pathway to resiliency. This is a personal quest and journey to understand the meaning of these traumatic events.

With my clients, I have personally utilized tools such as Matrix Re-imprinting and EFT, to answer the questions that need to be clarified to better

understand the meaning of the event, the learning of the event, and what is necessary to shift to a resilient and positive learning and re-imprinting. Post Traumatic Resilience is within our grasp and can lead to the freedom, peace and flourishing that will dramatically change the trajectory of our lives!

TRUST IN THE PROCESS OF LIFE



“I trust Life. I know it brings me everything that I need at the perfect time and in the perfect way.

Louise Hay

What if I do everything right and it feels like everything goes wrong? It almost feels like I'm being punished for something. Why is this happening?

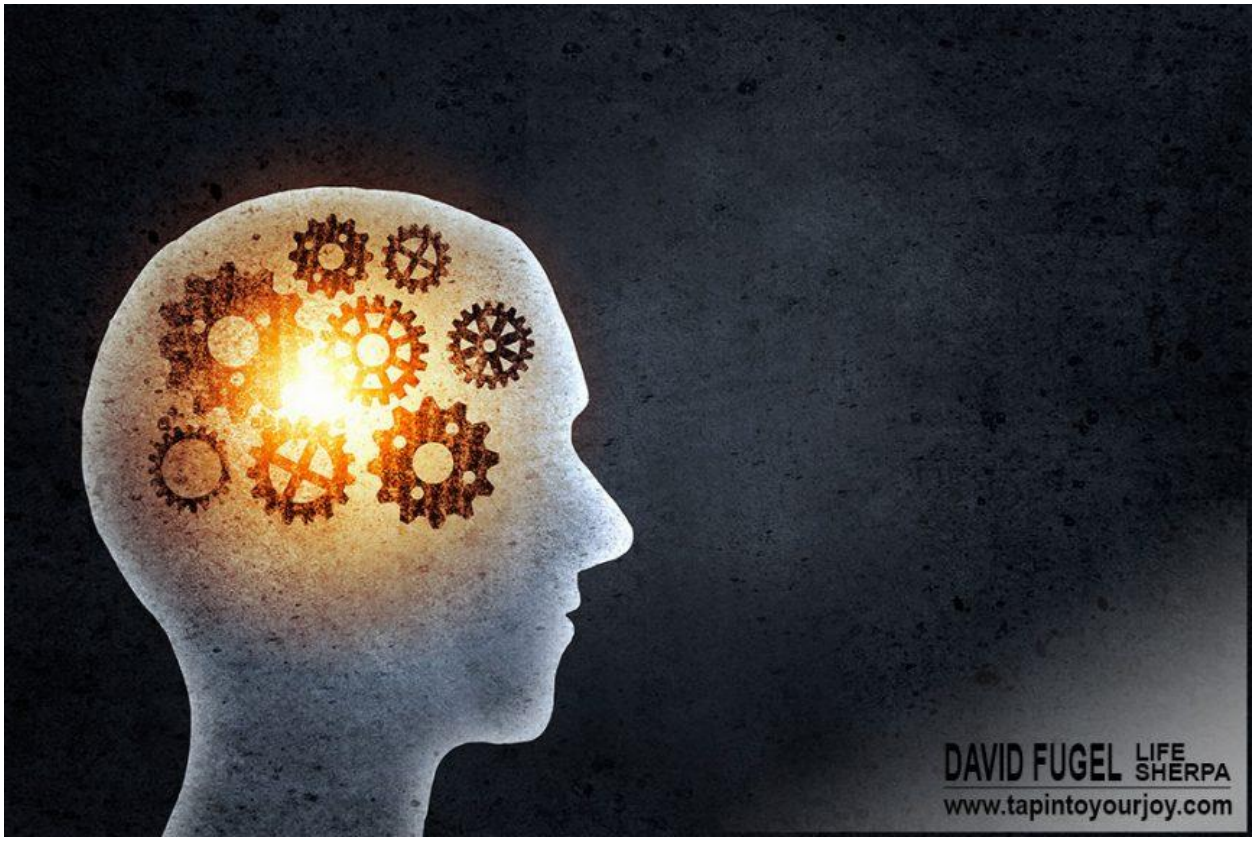
Have you been there?

The poem that follows has the exact energy of what's gotten me out of that thought pattern and into the place of hope, possibilities and trust. It put words to the feelings I have often had. I hope you enjoy it as much as I did.

"*When you don't get what you want, you quickly assume that it's because you don't deserve it or because you are not worthy enough to get it. But have you ever thought that it could be because it doesn't deserve you or because it is not worth of you? The truth is that we always give ourselves less credit than we deserve. And sometimes, many times, we live in denial of what we really deserve, so we settle for what is less. There is a power much higher than us, much wiser than us, that is willing to crush our feelings sometimes so that it can open our eyes to the strength that we have inside and to the reality of what we truly deserve.*"

– Najwa Zebianz

A PAUSE TO PROCESS



“Perspective happens in the pause.”

David Fugel

Was it the super moon the likes of which will not be seen for another 65 years, or was it the most unlikely election result in a lifetime? Take your pick.

The week following the election of Donald Trump to the presidency of United States was as intense and emotional as I have witnessed outside of 9/11. That week, almost every client that I saw or heard from on a group call were shocked, angry, confused, and stuck. I was taken aback by the intensity of their reaction. I did my best to shine the light of perspective on each situation.

In the days and weeks that followed, what became more and more apparent was the impact and destruction of fear. For months, people have been hearing threats. Most of those threats were dismissed because there was no possibility of them being executed because the man perceived by so many as being the bully of the election was going to lose.

> *Fear, real or perceived, is a destructive force.*

These are not my thoughts. These are the thoughts that came to the surface as we tried to work toward moving beyond what so many felt was a devastating loss. My thought is that fear, real or perceived, is a destructive force. It reminds me of the time that I really lost my temper in front of my five-year-old daughter. She recoiled in fear for that moment, so I reach for her to take her in my arms and make sure she knew that she was safe. But it is not that simple. She had the right and reason to be confused, and now she had to process whether the earlier threat or the warm embrace were real.

My take away from this whole experience is that we must all be very cautious of using fear as a weapon. Daily we see this as parents use it on their children, spouses toward one another, employers toward employees and vice versa. Donald Trump did not invent fear nor he does not have a monopoly on

it. He has given us the opportunity to see how ugly and painful it can be and to be aware of it wherever it may rear its ugly head.

I am also mindful that many of the people who changed their political allegiance in this election also acted out of fear. There is a palpable fear for many who have seen many aspects of their lives eroding. To dismiss their fear is as wrong as dismissing the remnants of fear felt by those that are struggling in the post-election.

What I recommended to each and every client in the struggle, as well as to those that are fearful that they might never get an opportunity to build their lives back to where they might be have been some years back, is to please get curious. Get curious about one another and in that curiosity find compassion.

In previous posts, I have said that ***compassion is the antidote to fear***, and it is never more apparent that it is a necessary antidote in all of our lives today.

Onward and upward!

SELF-CARE, ANOTHER WAY TO LOOK AT IT IS…

When you change the way you look at things, the things you look at change.

Wayne Dwyer

It is so easy to slip into the pattern of seeing challenging situations or obstacles that we are accustomed to, with familiar eyes and limiting beliefs. The question is, how do we shake things up and let the sunshine in?

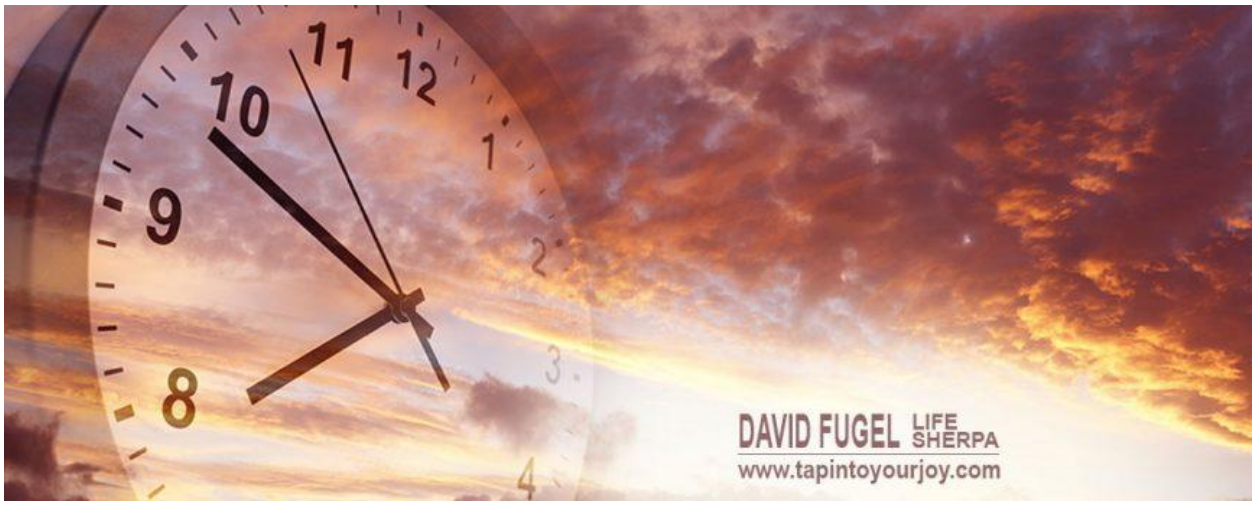
While I was studying Applied Positive Psychology, the professor recommended a simple way to shift ourselves out of our thinking ruts when we face what feels like an insurmountable challenge. By simply priming our thinking with the statement “another way to look at this is…”, we are expanding the possibilities and gaining peripheral perspective.

We are changing the way we are looking at things and allowing what we are looking at to change.

Try it with a problem you keeping bumping up against. It works wonders!

SELF-CARE, STOP THE TIME-TRAVEL OF ANXIETY AND REGRET

In Articles, Healing journey by David FugelJanuary 11, 20170 Comments



All negativity is caused by an accumulation of psychological time and denial of the present.

Unease, anxiety, tension, stress, worry—all forms of fear—are caused by too much future and not enough presence.

Guilt, regret, resentment, grievances, sadness, bitterness, and all forms of non-forgiveness are caused by too much past, and not enough presence.

— Eckert Tolle

There is enough information packed into this quote for me to stop right here, drop the mike and walk offstage. I must have read and re-read it 10 times to process it fully.

I find myself travelling through time without even realizing it. It manifests itself in the discomfort of anxiety when I am travelling into the future—worrying about things that will never happen—while I watch it drain the joy from anything that's happening in the present.

Or, I travel through time to visit the regret of things that have happened in the past which I can do nothing to change, while ignoring what I could change for the better in the present.

The best that I can do with this kind of time-travel is to become aware of it as early as possible. This helps me to snap out of it and be present to the blessings and joys that are all around me or in a worst-case scenario, affect change in the present and move to a better place that will serve me. I have stopped kidding myself that I can avoid this time-travel, and I have embraced the fact that I can control and minimize the amount of time that I spend in these most uncomfortable places. The contrast is exhilarating!

SELF-CARE, KNOW YOUR END GAME

Sometimes you put walls up not to keep people out, but to see who cares enough to break them down.

Socrates

There are few tests that are potentially more dangerous than to induce your own drowning to see who cares enough to rescue you.

This is a very familiar story in my childhood. Rather than showing up as their best self, I witnessed this constant isolation and self-victimization cycle, month after month, waiting for loved ones to prove themselves by this artificial and sadistic standard.

Even as a child, I had the notion that you would attract more bees with honey than a destructive bee trap. I think that is why I am repelled by the drama queens that “vant to be allooonnnne” only to snap when everyone honors their wishes.

I have worked diligently to be authentic. If I want attention, I let that be known. If I want isolation, you will know that too. What you see, (and I am not saying it is always pretty), is what you get.

This is how I chose to live based upon seeing the tormented eyes of those who would do anything to make the love of their life happy, but could not climb high enough or fast enough for their satisfaction.

Daily, I work to take back the reigns of control over my happiness because the only hoops that are to be jumped through are by me for me. That is what I can control. I am convinced that living a life of joy and satisfaction will attract or maintain people in my life that will not waste time and energy testing me by building walls for me to tear down so they can be happy!

SELF-CARE, CREATE UPWARD SPIRAL

METHOD TO MADNESS

Many self-care suggestions are great but to some, they might feel a bit “out there.” While many clients just trust and believe they will feel a difference, others feel weird as the exercises might feel awkward or pointless. Here is a little science to support these “mad” requests:

“It is all about creating an upward spiral. It often takes only a few positive emotions to kick-start the process which then begin to fuel positive changes in other areas of your life.

For example, movement aka exercise, changes the electrical activity in your brain during sleep, which then reduces anxiety, improves mood, and gives you more energy to exercise. Similarly, expressing gratitude activates serotonin production, which improves your mood and allows you to overcome bad habits, giving you more to be grateful for. Any tiny change can be just the push your brain needs to start spiraling upward.”

– *The Upward Spiral*, Alex Korb PHD

SELF-CARE, PUTTING ME FIRST

Recently I have been less active in my writing because I have been invested in yet another life transition. We are downsizing which does not really describe the full extent of the process. Releasing and trusting captures the process more accurately. But…

- **I love our home**
- **I love our town**
- **I love our friends**

They are the very reasons we resisted this move for 5 years. And they are all great reasons. But I love me enough to know that this transition is necessary for my well-being and expansion.

There comes a point in life where lightening our load and opening our hearts to new possibilities is a necessary thing. The result is putting me first and ahead of the comfort.

We have no idea where we will go from here. This is part of the adventure and excitement! Fifteen years ago, if you told me that we would consider doing this I would tell you that you were crazy. Now it is my feelings that are guiding me rather than the pursuit of acquisitions. Simplifying my life as well as having flexibility feels like the right direction.

I will keep the memories of this beautiful place and our loving family and friends who shared it with us in my heart forever. Now it is time to expand my heart and make room for more for the infinite possibilities that the Universe offers. Trusting and knowing that amazing times are ahead, keeps me balanced in what could be an overwhelming transition.

Stay tuned… the best is yet to come!

YES, THEY CAN!

It has been my great fortune to have had the opportunity to work alongside some of the most incredible women. Their strength has inspired me, their calm and cool has soothed me, and their brilliance has dazzled and educated me.

We dump so much on them, while the average man would crumble under the weight of such expectation. Yet they get on with life, carrying us most of the way. They do it without thanks, recognition or equal compensation.

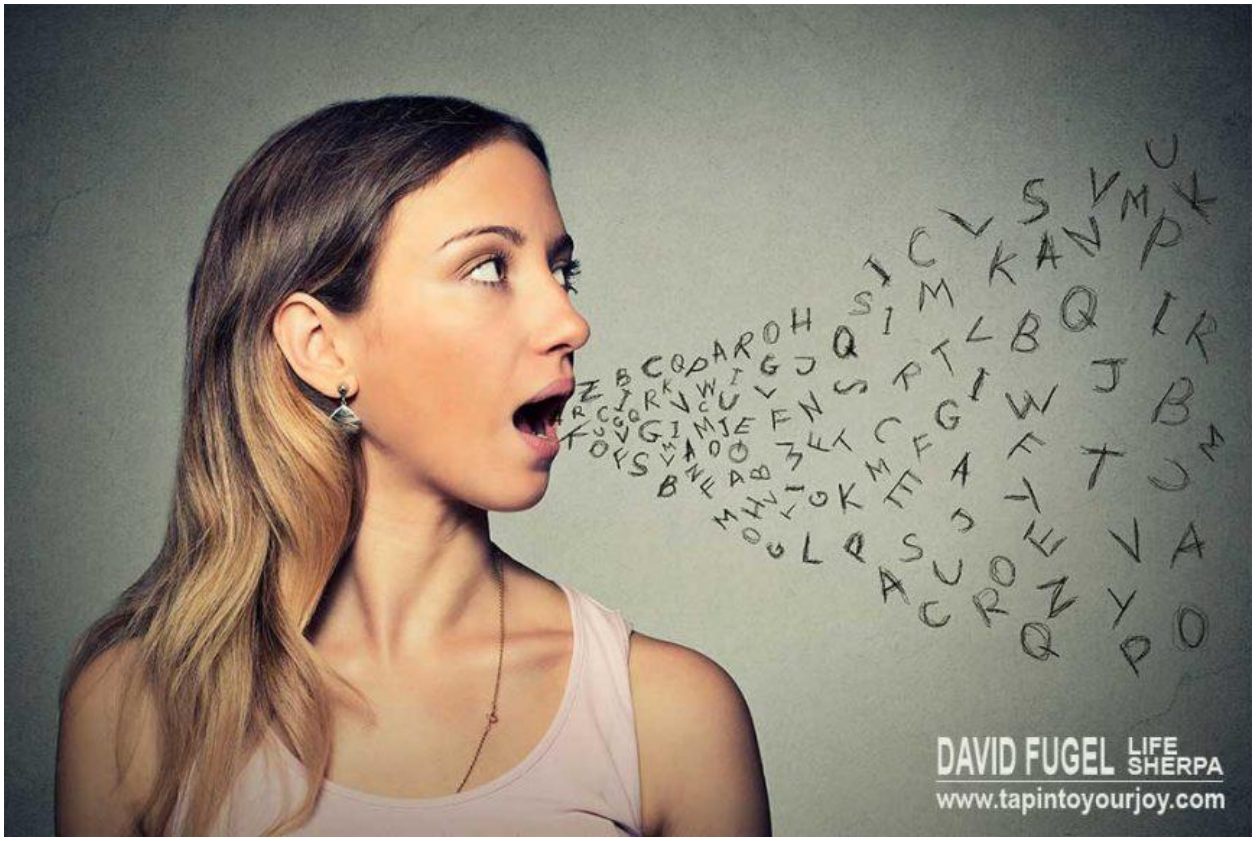
- Is it repayment for the rib?
  That debt has been repaid a billion times over.
- Is it because we had them convinced they were the weaker sex?
  The best defense is a good offense.

I think it is because women get it. They can and we can't. So they do and do and do. Don't be fooled… women do this at a cost to their well-being. On an occasional Saturday, I would visit our clothing store. Suddenly one of our clients would rush in, explaining that they had seconds, not minutes, to make their purchase because their husbands or children or parents or in-laws were waiting impatiently for them. The stress they carried would go right through me. And I was only an observer and did not have to live in their skin every stressful day. Don't let the exceptional "princess" that goes from yoga, to massage, to lunch with the girls, fool you. They are not the rule, but it makes us feel better about ourselves to believe they are.

I am in awe of you and needed to finally say it.

I am grateful to you and hope that I can bring to your world a fraction of the beauty and strength that you have brought to mine.

SELF-CARE, WORDS TO BE WEEDED!



In Minnesota, a study was completed of twins separated at birth. It is very interesting to discover what the influences were on their happiness:

- Genes account for 50%,
- Environment/circumstances accounts for 10%, and
- Intentional activities, (what we think, say and do) accounts for 40%!

What does this tell us? Whether you are a twin or not, our focus is best directed to intentional activities. Let's start with words. Words that can be eliminated resulting in a positive effect on our happiness are:

- Want
- Should
- Hate
- Can't
- Poor
- Never
- Impossible

Try it! Replace "want" with "desire", and "should" with "can" or "get to"! Nothing is "impossible".

Napoleon Hill said, "Whatever the mind can conceive and believe, the mind can achieve."

SELF-CARE, WORDS MAKE WORLDS!

Last chapter, Words to be Weeded, we looked at words that can be eliminated from our vocabulary which has a huge influence our happiness. These words do not serve our purpose to raise our vibration.

By clearing words that do not serve us, we have plenty of room for words that will create worlds!

Try adding these words on a regular basis and feel your heart and mind shift.

- Focus
- Abundance
- Prosperous/prosperity
- Love
- Desire
- Appreciate
- Determination
- Gratitude
- Confident
- Certainty
- Empowered
- Purpose

Enjoy these words to live by!

SELF-CARE, ACTIVATE YOUR CHOICE MUSCLE

“Active Your Choice Muscle… then, choose hope over despair.”

David Fugel

Being stuck means we feel as if we have no choice but to be in this place indefinitely. We go to emotional states of blame, resentment and languish in the fear of never leaving that spot.

What we do not realize is that we are in fact making choices constantly, and making no choice is a choice! Being a victim never feels like the choice that it actually is. Being the victim of life's ugliest offerings leaves us feeling helpless and hopeless. Falling into the victim mindset feels paralyzing and leads to despair.

At all times, the miracle that we have at our disposal is the miracle of choice. The more we use our choice muscle as a "go to" tool, the stronger the leverage we have over despair. We can choose to tap into this miraculous shift by choosing to crawl out of despair and choose to go toward hope. The transformative power of hope in undeniable.

The miracle of this power is that it is only a choice away.

SELF-CARE, AWAKEN YOUR INNER HERO AND BEGIN YOUR HEROIC JOURNEY

You are the hero of your own story.

Joseph Campbell

What I love about the energy of being the hero in my own story is that is shifts me out of the “victim energy”. The hero may be bloodied, broken, and beaten down, but finds the way to get up, put on his/her cape, and saves the day or in our scenario, a lifetime of days.

I picture Clark Kent, the weakling with nerdy glasses, being pushed around afraid of his own shadow. The Super-Victim. What were his “superpowers”? Whining, blaming, lamenting, and cowering. What do you think his comic book story would look like? The Riddler, Joker, Cat woman, and their gang would be coming out of the woodwork to get a look at this guy.

Here is what I think his story might look like.

I will always remember a man I worked with in New York City. Let’s call him Peter. Peter was average size and build and mostly quiet. When he did make noise, it was of a whiny nature, very defensive, and he pointed his finger a lot. He seemed to exist with minimum effort and force of personality.

One day, he came back after lunch with a big gash by the front pocket of his trousers. The white inner pocket was sticking out of the gash. When asked what had happened, he said that he was walking to the corner and someone came along from behind with a knife, slashed his pants and grabbed his wallet… AGAIN! The story was amazing and thankfully he was not hurt, but I zeroed in on the word AGAIN.

Out of curiosity, I asked what he meant by AGAIN. In a whiny tone, he said, “This is the sixth time! New York is a terrible place… full of criminals and I want to leave once and for all.”

I had to ask him why he carried around a bulging wallet in his front pocket. This felt like the ultimate victim energy. I told him he was putting a big “kick

me” sign on his back. He said that it has happened even when he hadn’t been carrying his wallet. He was walking around with “VICTIM ENERGY”.

VICTIM ENERGY OR HERO ENERGY

We have all done it, carrying this big “kick me” sign and guess what? We become VICTIMS.

I have been very conscious of the energy I have given off when in vulnerable positions. Without realizing it, I chose Hero Energy. We all have a choice when confronted with circumstances, villains, or challenges. What role have you chosen consistently?

As I examine my reactions, I realize that most of the time, I find my phone booth and put on my cape! I am now choosing to remain more aware and be in Hero Energy even when I am not being “attacked”. I am tapping into Hero Energy with the intention to transform my life into a Heroic Journey.

I can use all the support and companionship possible. Heroes’ welcome!